Ember: A From-Scratch GPU with an Integrated Int8 Tensor Unit Architecture, Bit-Exact Verification, and Block-Level Physical Design on SkyWater 130 nm

Toshal Kumbhar.
Independent project RTL, software, and silicon flow by one person
github.com/ October 23, 2026

Abstract—I present Ember, a GPU built completely from scratch without vendor IP, HLS or a borrowed rasterizer. It runs a real 3D game loop, a complete Doom level rasterized from the shareware IWAD, and a real neural network in RTL simulation. I am also evaluating its logic blocks through an open-source physical design flow to GDS-II on SkyWater 130 nm. The logical design contains a command processor with DMA and fences, a 512 KB unified VRAM, a four-lane IEEE-754 single-precision vector FPU, a geometry/setup engine, a multi-cycle rasterizer with a Z-buffer, CLUT texturing and a full read-modify-write output stage, a sprite blitter, vector video timing, and a 16×16 int8 weight-stationary tensor unit, all behind a single AXI4-Lite fabric. Every block is verified against an independent pure-Python golden model and is bit-exact: my cocotb suite passes 31/31 tests, including a CNN (LeNet-class) inference run at 98/100 = 98.0% accuracy through the real RTL data path with trained int8 weights, and a 32-frame input-driven 3D game loop whose physics runs as a kernel on the compute core. The worst measured frame takes 6.152 ms, 18.6% of a 30 fps budget, using a 100 MHz cycle-to-time conversion. These frequencies are evaluation assumptions, not achieved post-layout operating frequencies. Physical design targets twelve blocks through Yosys, OpenROAD, Magic and KLayout. The generated results currently record 11 completed synthesis targets and 6 exported block layouts with independently audited zero routing violations and whole-layout Magic DRC errors. Remaining blocks, LVS, timing closure, physical SRAM and chip integration are unfinished. I close with engineering lessons drawn from the debugging process, which I consider the most transferable part of this project.

Index Terms—GPU architecture, rasterization, systolic array, int8 quantization, ASIC implementation, sky130, open-source EDA, verification by golden model.

I. Introduction

There are two ways to learn how a GPU works. The first is to read about it. The second is to build one and watch it fail in ways no textbook describes. This paper is about the second path.

Ember started from a deliberately awkward goal: build a GPU from scratch that can run both a basic AI workload and a basic game, on real hardware, with an entirely open-source toolchain. "From scratch" is load-bearing here: the rasterizer, the floating-point unit, the tensor array, the instruction set, the assembler, the golden models, the C driver and the place-and-route are all in this project. The only external pieces are a RISC-V soft core (NEORV32) as the host, the sky130 process design kit, and the open EDA tools.

That constraint shaped everything. An FPU written from scratch means you must come to terms with IEEE-754 subnormals, round-to-nearest-even, and what "flush-to-zero" does to your depth values at 2 a.m. A rasterizer written from scratch means you derive plane equations for $1/w$, colour, u, v and depth, and then discover that your interpolator is off by one bit at the right edge of the screen. A tensor unit written from scratch means you learn why weight-stationary systolic arrays are shaped the way they are, and why the tricky part is not the multiplier array but the address generator feeding it.

The result is a small but genuine GPU. It is not fast and it does not pretend to be: its rasterizer uses multiple cycles per pixel and its tensor array is streaming-limited. The RTL demos are verified; physical implementation is a separate, incomplete workstream. I also find the "wrong" parts of the story more useful to other engineers than the successful parts, so I document them explicitly in Section X.

Contributions

- A complete, verified GPU architecture (Section III): command processor, unified memory, geometry engine, rasterizer with Z-buffer and texturing, blitter, display, compute core and tensor unit, with a documented register map and command queue format.
- A 32-bit SIMT-style ISA and assembler (Section IV) used to write real kernels, including a fixed-point game-physics kernel that runs the demo's per-frame integration on the chip itself.
- An int8 tensor unit that actually infers (Section VI): a LeNet-class CNN trained in pure Python, quantized, and executed through the RTL at 98.0% accuracy, bit-identical to a software mirror.
- A real game level through the same pipeline (Section V-D): 10,774 textured triangles built from

Doom's own BSP geometry, composed wall textures, flats and light tables, rasterized by the RTL bit-exactly against the golden model (76,800 of 76,800 pixels).
- A verification methodology that scales down (Section VII): one golden model per block, differential testing, structural assertions for demos where no golden pixel exists, and a 31/31 suite.
- Block-level ASIC flow evaluation (Section VIII): measured synthesis and layout results with explicit completion status, independent exported-GDS checks and unresolved implementation limits.
- An honest lessons section (Section X) covering the bugs that a textbook would not warn you about.

II. Related Work

Open-source GPUs. RasterIX, voodoo-fpga and Polyphony demonstrate hardware rasterization on FPGAs; Project F provides well-documented FPGA graphics building blocks. They concentrate on the graphics pipe. GPGPU research includes MIAOW (an open AMD GCN RTL implementation), Nyuzi and Vortex, which are RISC-V GPGPU designs with real compiler stacks. These target much larger platforms than this design. Tensor hardware spans Google's TPU v1 (a 256×256 int8 systolic array) down to Gemmini and many FPGA CNN accelerators; the weight-stationary dataflow I use is the classic Kung–Leiserson arrangement that the TPU paper brought back into fashion. Verification practice in the open-source world is dominated by cocotb plus Verilator; I lean heavily on that pairing and on the discipline of writing an independent model in a different language from the RTL.

What distinguishes Ember is not any single block. It is that the graphics pipe, the tensor pipe, the compute cores, the host interface and the physical implementation all exist in one coherent design, verified end-to-end by software that also runs on the chip's own instruction set.

III. Architecture

Figure 1 shows the chip. There is one memory system and two accelerators: a graphics pipe and a tensor pipe.

A. Command Processor and Memory

The host never talks to an accelerator directly. It talks to the CP, which owns a small register file, a 64-entry upload FIFO, an 8-entry readback FIFO, a DMA engine, a completion counter used as a fence, and one "kick" register per accelerator:

Register	Function
STATUS	dma/rtr/blit/cp/core/tu busy + readback level
FIFOD	write = push upload word, read = pop readback word
DMA_SRC/DST/LEN	FIFO→VRAM and VRAM→FIFO transfers
RTR_KICK	start a triangle sweep from the command queue
BLIT_*	rectangle source/destination/size/flags
GSX_*	matrix, vertex stream, colour, configuration, go
CORE_CODE/NBLK/KICK	load and launch a kernel
TU_*	operand bases, dimensions, quantization, go

VRAM is 512 KB and holds everything: the framebuffer at 0x000000, the Z-buffer at 0x025800, texture pages at 0x04B000, the RTR command queue at 0x05B000 and kernel code at 0x05B400. That single flat map is deliberately simple: any debug tool, any golden model and any driver can address any pixel with one 32-bit number. The map went through a painful revision early on, the original layout had the command buffer overrun the end of memory and wrap into the framebuffer, and the fix taught me to size every region against the fabric's real capacity rather than its nominal one.

B. Interconnect

A 2×2 AXI4-Lite crossbar connects two masters (host and CP-DMA) to two slaves (CP registers and VRAM), with round-robin arbitration and a lock-based forwarding scheme so that a read-modify-write sequence cannot be split by the other master. The rasterizer, blitter and display bypass the fabric on dedicated pixel ports, reducing contention with host accesses during rendering.

IV. Compute Core and Instruction Set

The compute core is a four-thread SPMD machine executing a 32-bit Ember-ISA v2. Sixteen general-purpose registers plus three read-only ones (%blockIdx, %blockDim, %threadIdx) are provided per thread; each thread has its own program counter and its own one-word instruction buffer. Instructions fall into four classes:

- Integer ALU: ADD, SUB, MUL, DIV, MIN, MAX, AND, OR, XOR, SHL, SHR, CMP.
- Floating point: FADD, FSUB, FMUL, FDIV, issued to the vector FPU.
- Memory: LD/ST through one port, LDS/STS to per-core shared memory with ATOMIC_ADD and ATOMIC_MAX.
- Control: BRNZP, JAL, JR, CALL, RET and the block barrier BAR.

Two design decisions in this core are worth calling out because they were forced by deadlocks rather than chosen for elegance. First, the fetch channel and the data channel are separate VRAM ports: with one shared read port, a thread waiting on a load holds the instruction buffer while the fetch that would unblock it cannot be issued, a circular wait that hangs the core forever. Second, instruction buffers are per thread: with a single shared buffer, thread 0 reaches the barrier, its next word wedges the buffer, and threads 1–3 never arrive, the classic broken barrier. Both fixes are invisible in a tiny test and fatal in a real one.

Kernels are written in assembly and assembled by my two-pass assembler, which supports labels, .word/.string/.org directives and pc-relative branches. Real kernels in the repository include matrix multiply, 2×2 max-pool with a signed-byte trick, and the game-state kernel below.

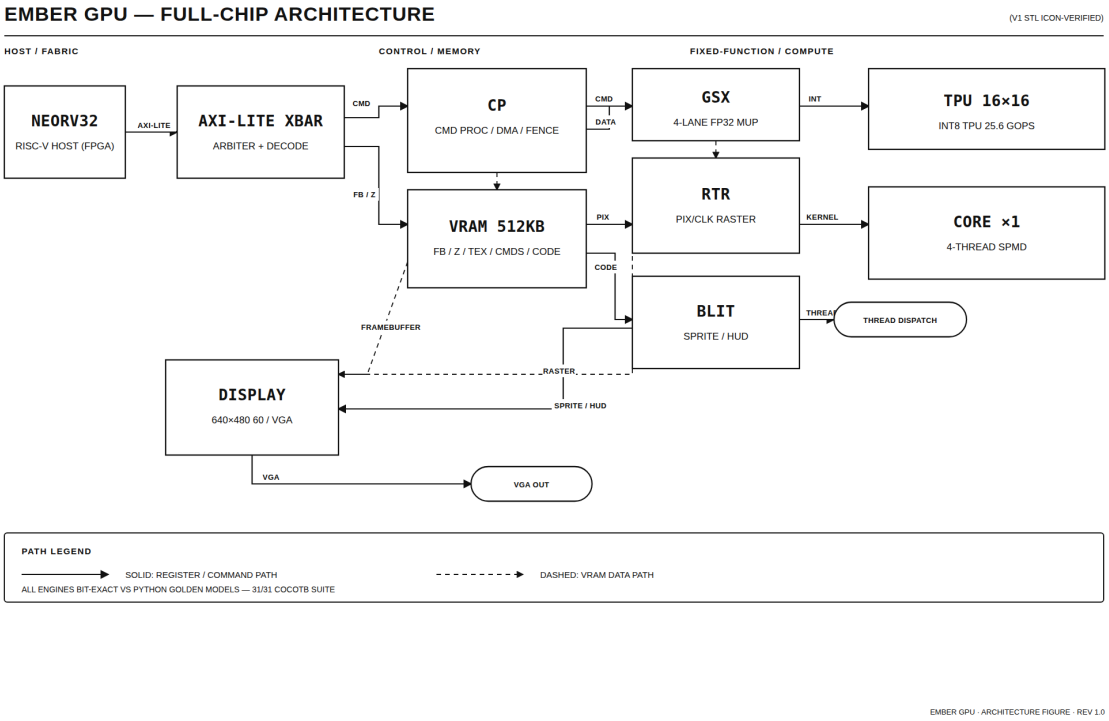


Fig. 1. The Ember chip. Solid arrows are register/command paths; dashed arrows are VRAM data paths. The host drives a flat AXI4-Lite port; the crossbar decodes to the command processor and VRAM. Every accelerator is started by a register write from the CP and reports completion through STATUS. The rasterizer, blitter and display own dedicated VRAM pixel ports, reducing fabric contention during multi-cycle rasterization.

A. The game-state kernel: a game loop on the chip

The most satisfying moment in this project was moving the camera physics out of the testbench and onto the core. gamestate.asm (112 words) runs a Q16.16 fixed-point loop, once per frame, on thread 0:

```
; in = input word (bit0 = forward, bit1 = left, bit2 = right)
vel += in*ACC          ; accelerate, ACC = 1638 (0.025/frame^2)
f   = |vel| >> 4       ; friction: 1/16 of speed per frame
vel -= sign(vel)*f     ; signed decay, symmetric
vel  = clamp(vel, -VMAX, +VMAX)
pos += vel             ; integrate
pos  = clamp(pos, x in [-2,2], z in [0,1])
out  = f2q(pos)        ; exact Q16 -> IEEE-754 fp32 bit pattern
```

The kernel then writes the camera state back to VRAM and echoes a cookie so the host can confirm completion, and precomputes the one MVP word it can compute exactly (a pure Q16 add), leaving the other to the host because it needs a 37-bit product. The physics is bit-exact against the Python mirror on all 32 frames of the demo, meaning the camera walk you see in Figure 5 is the result of instructions executed by the GPU.

V. Graphics Pipeline

A. GSX: geometry and setup

The geometry engine contains a four-lane IEEE-754 single-precision FPU built from scratch: round-to-nearest-even, flush-to-zero, correct NaN/Inf handling and a fixed six-cycle latency (issue on cycle N, result at $N+5$), fixed latency rather than a busy/wait protocol, because polling a busy flag raced the lane state machine and occasionally read a zero result.

GSX loads a 4×4 MVP matrix, streams vertices five words at a time (x, y, z, u, v), transforms them four at a time, divides x/w, y/w, z/w in one parallel FPU pass, culls triangles with $w \leq 0$, converts to Q10.22 and to a 16-bit depth, and emits 19-word command packets into the command queue in VRAM. The pipeline is deliberately fixed-function: this is a PS1-class machine, and a machine that draws correctly is worth more here than a programmable shader that draws slowly.

B. RTR: rasterize, texture, output

Setup uses Cramer's rule on the triangle's edge functions to produce plane coefficients for $1/w$, red, green, blue, z, u and v; the $1/w$ plane is constant in this revision, which is why texturing is affine. The scan unit then walks the bounding box through multi-cycle coverage test, plane evaluation, a divide for perspective-correct interpolation, Z-test (less-than), CLUT texture lookup, and a full read-modify-write output stage: clamping, colour mapping, optional 50% blend, ±1 ordered dither, and RGB565 packing into a byte-packed framebuffer.

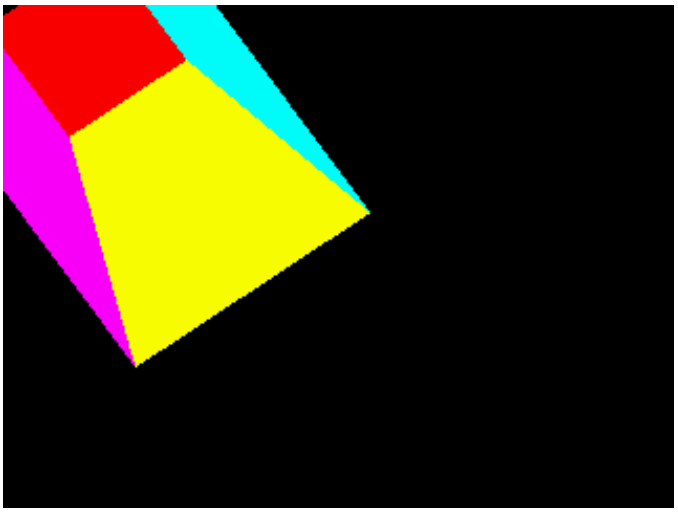


Fig. 2. A spinning cube rendered by the RTL rasterizer, per-pixel bit-exact against the golden model. The gradient background comes from the same fixed-function pipeline.

Triangle commands are fetched from a zero-terminated 19-word-per-triangle queue, which means the rasterizer never needs a bus transaction to learn what to do next.

C. Blitter and display

The blitter copies rectangles with optional colour-key transparency and 1× or 2× scaling, enough to composite a HUD sprite over the scene, which is exactly what the game demo does. Display provides 640×480 at 60 Hz with a 320×240 double-scan mode, fetching pixels through its own VRAM port and emitting aligned sync, blanking and data signals.

D. A real level: Doom E1M1

A spinning cube proves the pipeline adds up; a real game level proves it is actually correct, because every wall, flat, light level and texture offset is someone else's ground truth. Ember renders the first level of Doom from the shareware IWAD (data/doom1.wad) by reading the WAD itself: BSP nodes and subsectors select the visible segs, sector light levels index the colormap table for light diminishing, patch-composed wall textures and 64×64 flats are assembled from the WAD's patch directory, and the vanilla projection is reproduced exactly.

Geometry fidelity comes from emitting Doom's own decomposition instead of dicing triangles in screen space. Every wall column becomes one quad with u constant and v affine in y; every plane row becomes one quad, since a level camera puts all pixels of a row at a single distance, making u affine in x and v constant. Depth is $1 - near/dist$, which is affine in screen space, so the 16-bit z plane interpolates exactly. The result is 10,774 textured triangles in 12 texture-atlas batches, streamed into the real command queue over the command processor's DMA engine with one 1 KB palette load; the rasterizer resolves each texel through that CLUT with the per-triangle palette bit rather than grey-expanding it.

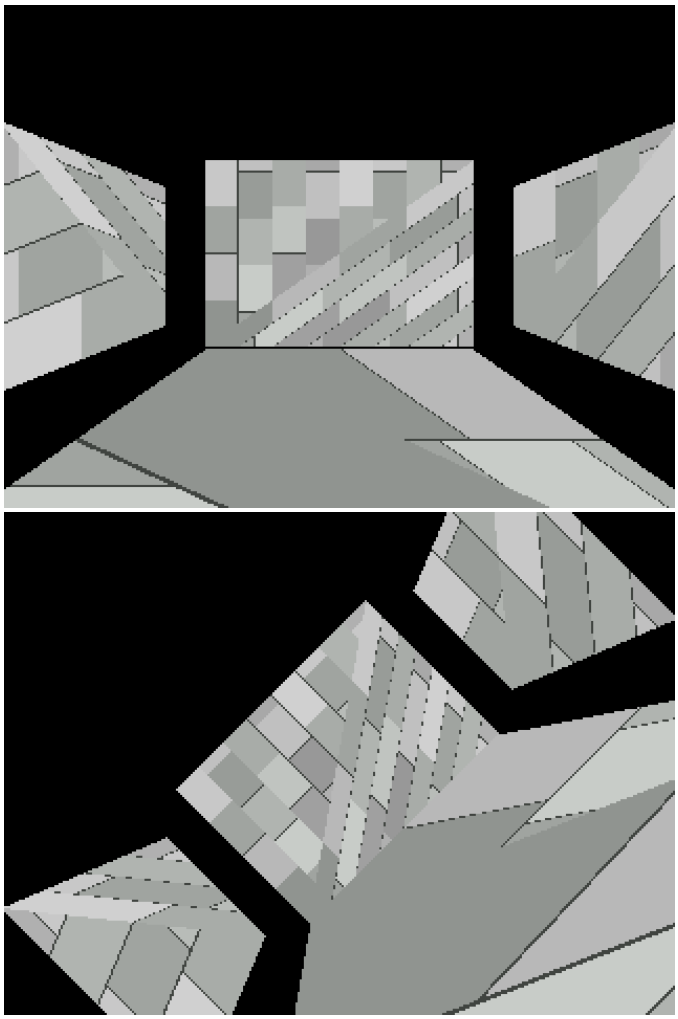


Fig. 3. Orbiting the temple: two frames of a four-frame orbit animation, each rendered end-to-end through GSX→RTR and verified bit-exact. The scene is eight textured triangles: back wall, floor and two pillars, using a procedural brick page.

Figure 6 is the strongest evidence in this paper that the graphics pipeline is correct, precisely because no part of the level was designed to flatter it. The frame out of the RTL is bit-identical to the golden model, which is itself an independent implementation of Doom's projection and texture lookup. What is missing is equally clear: sprites, and therefore monsters, items and the weapon, because sprite patches are transparent-columned and the rasterizer has no colour-key or alpha path yet; a sprite quad today would be drawn inside a black box.

VI. Tensor Unit

The tensor unit is a 16×16 int8 weight-stationary systolic array with per-column adder trees, a blocked-M controller and a per-tensor requantization stage that rounds half-up. It is the AI half of the machine.

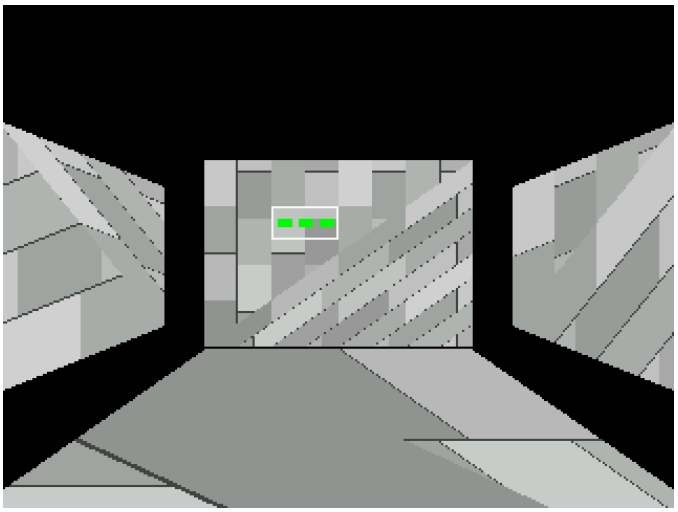


Fig. 4. The interactive fly-through: HUD sprite blitted over the temple with colour-key transparency. Worst frame measured 6.152 ms, 18.6% of a 30 fps budget at an assumed 100 MHz; it takes about 12.3 ms at 50 MHz.

Its control logic turned out to be the hard part. Three separate bugs shared one root cause: counters that were too narrow. Because the array streams full 16-byte tiles, both K and N must be multiples of sixteen; a 4-byte multiple silently reads the next row's bytes as padding and smears the output diagonally. Because the controller walks M in blocks, every "$M \times$ anything" counter needs enough bits: with a 688-row convolution output, an 8-bit row counter aliased writes from rows 256–687 back onto rows 0–255, and the square 256-cube test could not possibly catch it.

A. Inference, end to end

I trained a LeNet-class CNN (conv $1\to4$ 3×3, pool, conv $4\to8$ 3×3, pool, dense $200\to32\to10$) in pure Python with He initialization, a global gradient-norm clip of 400, and an epoch decay of 0.9, then quantized it to int8 with pure-shift requantization and folded the biases into the tensor unit's adder taps. Inference runs the image through the real RTL data path: DMA into VRAM, conv on the tensor unit, pooling as a kernel on the compute core, conv, pool, dense, dense, with the golden chain computed in software from the same operands. RTL and software agree exactly, and accuracy is $98/100 = 98.0\%$ on the first hundred test images.

Sustained throughput on a 256×256×256 multiplication is 2,134,296 cycles. At an assumed 100 MHz that is 1.57 GOPS sustained against a peak of 51.2 GOPS at the same frequency, about 3.1% of peak. At 50 MHz, both rates halve (0.786 and 25.6 GOPS). This is the honest cost of the v1 controller: it issues tiles and waits, and the array spends most of its life streaming operands rather than multiplying. Fixing that (operand double-buffering and a streaming controller) is the single largest performance opportunity in the design, and it is deliberately left to the next revision rather than papered over here.

VII. Verification

Every block in this design was verified the same way: write an independent model in a different language from the RTL, feed both the same stimulus, and require bit-exact equality. The models live in tools/golden/ and are pure Python, with no numpy, no floats where the hardware is fixed-point, and explicit modelling of every truncation and rounding step. That last point is what makes them useful: a golden model that is "morally" correct while the RTL truncates will disagree on a third of the pixels and send you hunting for bugs that do not exist.

The cocotb suite (Verilator backend) contains 31 tests and passes 31/31. It covers memory and DMA round trips, bit-exact rasterization including affine texturing and Z-ordering, the FPU (6,720 comparisons, zero mismatches), the geometry engine, the compute core (including divergence and barriers), the tensor unit (small multi-tile, quantized, and a 256-cube gate), MNIST layer by layer and end to end, animation, and the interactive demos. The Doom bench (Section V-D) goes further than the scene demos: it compares a complete 320×240 level frame against the golden rasterizer, pixel for pixel, and reports zero mismatches.

A. Verifying a demo with no golden pixels

Frames that combine a 3D scene with a blitted HUD cannot be compared pixel-for-pixel against a golden model without reimplementing the whole system in Python. Instead the demo tests assert structural properties that a broken renderer cannot satisfy: at least twelve distinct colours, at least 20,000 non-background pixels, at least fifty distinct depth values, consecutive frames that differ, and, most importantly, that the HUD's transparent pixels show the pre-blit scene, which is checked against a snapshot taken before the blit.

That last check is the kind of thing that sounds paranoid and is not. An earlier version of this project passed a texture test with a golden model that never loaded its own checkerboard: golden rendered black, RTL rendered black because it had lost a single enable bit, and black equalled black for an entire phase. Since then, every demo test must fail loudly if the golden side is degenerate.

B. The host interface, without hardware

The design's host interface is a set of memory-mapped registers, and the firmware that will run on the NEORV32 is plain C (sw/cp_driver.h, sw/ember_demo.c). To prove that interface before owning a board, I compile the firmware as a normal translation unit against a Verilator harness that implements a cycle-accurate AXI4-Lite master, and run it against the full top level. The demo executes all 32 frames, uploads textures, launches kernels, polls completion cookies, drives the geometry engine and the



Fig. 5. The input-driven camera walk, frames 0, 10, 24 and 30 of 32. Per-frame input words are consumed by the game-state kernel on the compute core; the camera's resulting fp32 position patches the MVP matrix; the scene is then rendered by the rasterizer. Physics is bit-exact against the golden model on every frame; 16 of the 32 frames are rasterized to keep simulation time sane.



Fig. 6. Doom E1M1. (a) the real engine at the player start, for reference; (b) Ember's golden rasterizer fed 10,774 triangles built from the WAD; (c) the same frame read back out of ember_rtr_top in Verilator after being DMA'd into the command queue. Frames (b) and (c) are identical: 76,800 of 76,800 pixels, 0 mismatches. 68.4 ms of simulated time, 232 s of wall clock. The reference is letterboxed: Doom renders 320×200, Ember 320×240.



Fig. 7. Ten real MNIST test digits (one per class) with the digit predicted by the trained int8 model, the same weights the RTL tensor unit executes. Nine of ten are correct; the miss is a genuinely ambiguous "3" that the int8 network calls an "8".

rasterizer, and draws its final frame. That frame matches the cocotb testbench's frame 30 on 10,316 of 10,316 scene pixels. The firmware that will ship is the firmware that was tested.

VIII. ASIC Implementation

The logical design is only half of a GPU. The other half is geometry: polygons, wells, routes, and a GDS-II file that a foundry could, in principle, accept. I run a custom block-level flow inside the OpenLane 2 tool container. Using that container does not mean the complete OpenLane sign-off flow has been executed. The block implementation stages are:

1) SystemVerilog → Verilog-2005 with sv2v. My RTL uses packages and packed structs, which Yosys's built-in frontend rejects; sv2v inlines packages and lowers structs to vectors, giving clean Verilog-2005 that any tool can read.
2) Logic synthesis with Yosys 0.46 and ABC, targeting the sky130 high-density standard-cell library, with the sky130_fd_sc_hd__tt_025C_1v80 corner.
3) Floorplan, placement, clock tree and routing with OpenROAD: 20–30% target utilization, routability-driven global placement, repair plus detailed placement, CTS, RC estimation and detailed routing.
4) DRC and GDS export with Magic, then final GDS normalization with KLayout.

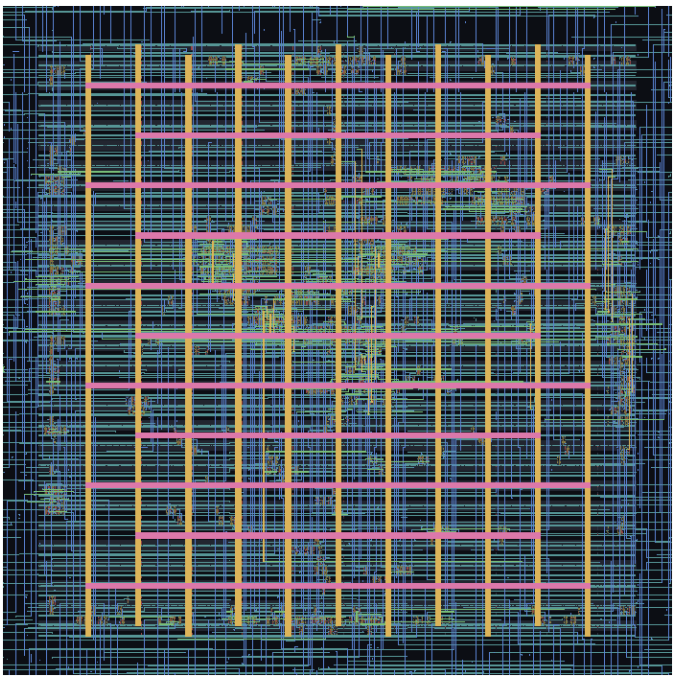


Fig. 8. Actual crossbar block layout rendered from independently audited GDS-II: 182.5×182.5 μm. Routing and whole-layout Magic DRC report zero errors. This is an individual block, not an integrated GPU die.

Table I lists the twelve blocks (rasterizer scan and setup,

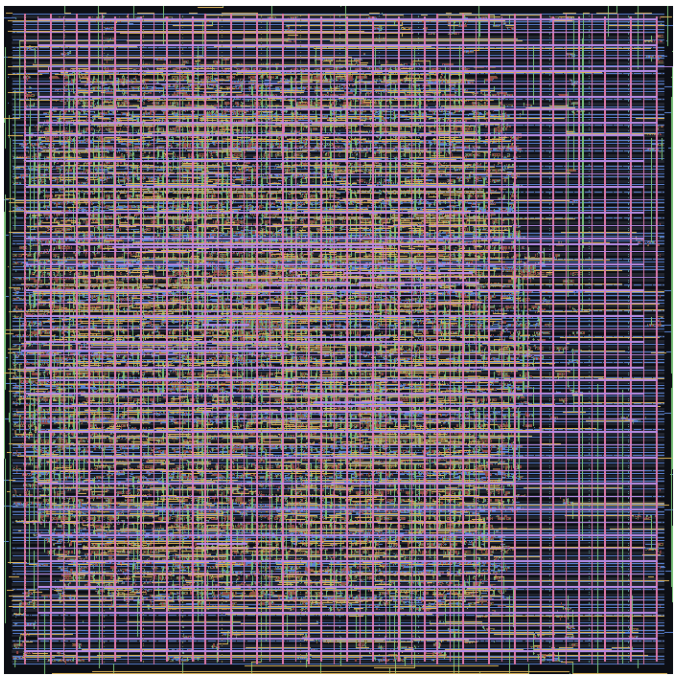


Fig. 9. Actual command-processor exported layout, 706.475×706.475 μm on sky130. Detailed routing and the independent whole-layout Magic audit both report zero violations. Colour denotes physical layer; LVS and timing sign-off remain pending.

the full rasterizer top, the vector FPU, the geometry engine, the blitter, display, command processor, crossbar, register-file slave, compute core and tensor unit) with cell counts, design area, routed wire length, worst negative slack against a 20 ns target clock, DRC count and GDS size.

Two synthesis issues required explicit corrections. Behavioral processes must be lowered before custom technology mapping; a successful tool exit alone did not prove a fully mapped netlist. I validate the exported JSON netlist for residual processes and generic cells. The multiplier-heavy raster scan unit also exceeded available memory during ABC mapping. A reduced mapping script and ripple-carry arithmetic mapping produced a validated netlist, but not a completed physical layout. These are implementation experiments, not evidence of timing closure.

A. Integrated-die implementation status

I have prepared an integration candidate containing eight top-level logic macros: crossbar, command processor, tensor unit, compute core, geometry engine, blitter, rasterizer top and display. The vector FPU, register slave, and raster setup and scan occur within parent blocks; placing all twelve standalone targets on a die would duplicate functionality. The candidate's synthesized wrapper contains 261 cells in total, including eight macro instances and 253 standard cells. Corrected accelerator memory-port wiring is included in this netlist.

TABLE I
SkyWater sky130 hardening results, per block. Cells are mapped standard cells after synthesis (hierarchical wrappers include macro instances); area and wire length are from the latest available physical run; DRC is the exported-layout audit count when verified, otherwise the available Magic count; missing entries are not completed results. WNS is worst negative slack against a 20 ns (50 MHz) target.

Block	Cells	Area (μm^2)	Wire (μm)	WNS (ns)	DRC	GDS (KB)
rtr_scan	1416166	-	-	-	-	-
rtr_setup	20782	150387	853284	0.00	0	57106
rtr_top	-	-	-	-	-	-
fpu4	101131	712822	3665444	-48.87	-	38284
gsx	113334	-	-	-	-	-
blit	2169	22326	81022	0.00	0	8652
display	454	6061	16149	0.00	0	2100
cp	7593	119186	568455	0.00	0	40451
xbar	267	3187	68220	0.00	0	2571
ram_slave	158	5573	22661	0.00	0	1850
core	347494	-	-	-	-	-
tu	257363	-	-	-	-	-

This candidate exposes VRAM-facing interfaces at die ports. It is an external-memory logic variant, not a physical implementation of the original 512 KB on-chip-memory GPU. A compatible memory implementation, macro interface checks, power connectivity, inter-block routing, full-die DRC, LVS and extracted timing remain necessary. No integrated-die GDS has been completed or independently audited. Figure 8 therefore shows an actual verified block, not a full chip.

IX. Results

A. Graphics

The rasterizer is a multi-cycle FSM, not a one-pixel-per-clock pipeline. The worst frame of the interactive fly-through (eight textured triangles plus a keyed HUD sprite over 320×240) takes 613,000 cycles in the rasterizer and 2,067 cycles in the blitter: 6.152 ms at an assumed 100 MHz, or 12.303 ms at 50 MHz. These occupy about 18.5% and 36.9% of a 33.3 ms budget, respectively. The orbit animation and the input-driven walk show the same order of magnitude. That is a cycle-based simulation estimate, not an achieved silicon clock rate.

B. Inference

98.0% accuracy on the first hundred MNIST test images, through the real RTL data path, with the software mirror agreeing exactly. Sustained tensor throughput is 1.57 GOPS at 100 MHz in this revision.

C. Sim-to-silicon

Table I reports the current per-block evidence, not a completed chip. 6 blocks (crossbar, display, register slave, blitter, command processor and raster setup) have exported GDS independently checked by reimporting and flattening the placed design in Magic with all rules enabled. Tapless library masters fail well-tap checks in isolation, so those checks require the assembled context

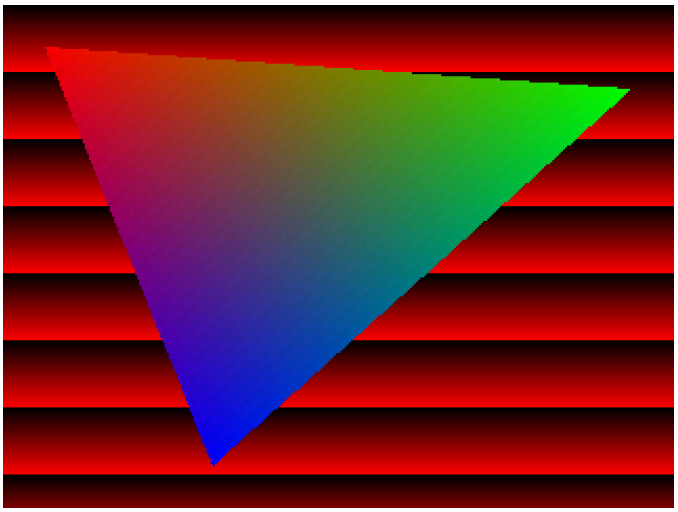


Fig. 10. Composite frame captured from the display pipeline: rasterized triangle over a gradient, doubled to 640×480 by the display's double-scan path.

with neighbouring tap cells. The generated table records 11 completed synthesis targets. Raster setup and scan have mapped-netlist evidence; the rasterizer top currently has a glue netlist with blackboxed setup and scan, not a completed physical macro. An earlier zero-exit synthesis run was rejected because ABC skipped modules containing processes. Physical builds of the remaining targets are in progress. No LVS pass, timing closure, pad ring, implemented 512 KB SRAM or electrically routed chip assembly is claimed. Parent and child targets overlap and their cell counts must not be summed as the area of a single GPU.

X. What Went Wrong, and What It Taught Me

The following are the bugs that cost the most time. I list them because they generalize far beyond this project.

A single shared instruction buffer makes barriers deadlock. Thread 0 reaches the barrier first; its next fetched instruction wedges the only buffer; the buffer never frees; threads 1–3 never execute. The fix, per-thread one-word buffers, looks obvious after you have spent a day staring at a core that looks perfectly alive and makes no progress.

Fetch and load must not share a port. The same circular wait, one level down: a thread waiting on a load holds the instruction buffer while the fetch that would unblock it cannot get the memory port. Separate ports fix it.

Only one instruction sets the flags. In this ISA, CMP sets neg/zero/pos and every other ALU operation is flag-silent. A kernel that subtracts and then branches on the result simply never loops, and it looks like a hang, not like a logic error.

Branch condition letters name the flags tested, not the meaning. BRNZP nz branches when negative or zero, not "if not zero". A three-way sign split written that way silently took the wrong path; two branches in my physics kernel had to become single-flag branches.

Logical shifts bite signed values. Computing friction as (K*v) » 16 is a catastrophe for negative velocities, because the shift is logical: a negative product becomes a huge positive number and slams the velocity into the clamp. The fix is magnitude-plus-sign, not arithmetic, and the golden model must reproduce the branch exactly.

Wide counters are a correctness requirement, not a detail. The tensor unit's M counter at 8 bits aliased 688 output rows onto 256; the square 256-cube test could not fail. Test non-square shapes even when the flagship gate test is square.

Reading a result the same cycle you request it, races. The FPU's busy-poll protocol occasionally sampled a stale zero. Fixed-latency interfaces are easier to verify than free-running ones; where I could not use fixed latency I had to define, precisely, which cycle a value is valid.

Memory layouts hide bugs better than logic does. Two of the worst week-long bugs in this project were stride errors: a row stride reused for a column stride (invisible when $K = N$) and an op-major tensor output consumed as plane-major (which scrambles channels silently). Both were only caught by comparing intermediate values, layer by layer, rather than final results.

A test can pass for the wrong reason, and that is the dangerous case. Black equalled black through a whole phase. My response was structural: every demo test now asserts properties that a degenerate renderer cannot satisfy.

Simulation time is a design constraint. Keeping 32 frames inside one foreground run forced me to sample the framebuffer rather than dump it, to render every other frame while advancing physics every frame, and to find out the hard way that skipping the framebuffer clear leaves stale pixels piled into sawtooth "mountains" that lower-bound assertions cannot detect.

XI. Availability and Reproducibility

Everything is in one repository: RTL, golden models, assembler, kernels, cocotb tests, the bare-metal C driver and demo, the Verilator host harness, the layout scripts and this paper's sources. The only external requirements are Verilator, cocotb, Yosys, OpenROAD, Magic, KLayout, sv2v and a sky130 PDK, all open source. make lint and cd test && make reproduce the verification results; scripts/gds/run_all.sh reproduces the layout flow.

XII. Conclusion

Building a GPU from scratch is a good way to learn how much of computer architecture is about interaction rather than invention. The multiplier array, the rasterizer FSM and the crossbar are each textbook objects; almost every hour of debugging in this project went into the interfaces between them: who owns the memory port, who sets the flags, which counter is wide enough, which buffer can block

whose progress. Ember now runs a real neural network at 98% accuracy on the 100-image evaluation subset, a simulated 3D game loop, and several DRC-checked routed block layouts on an open process. Those results address the goal I set. In the spirit of the lessons section, I am clear about what it is not: not fast, not manufacturable without sign-off work, and not the last revision.

Acknowledgment

All EDA tools used here are open source, and every result in this paper was produced on a single Windows/WSL machine. Earlier synthesis runs used a 21 GB WSL allocation; current physical builds run with a 16 GB cap. Thanks to the maintainers of Verilator, cocotb, Yosys, OpenROAD, Magic, KLayout and the sky130 PDK.

References

[1] N. Jouppi et al., "In-datacenter performance analysis of a tensor processing unit," ISCA, 2017.

[2] H. T. Kung and C. E. Leiserson, "Systolic arrays for VLSI," Sparse Matrix Proceedings, 1978.

[3] N. K. Vedula et al., "MIAOW: An open source GPGPU," ISCA, 2014.

[4] B. Tine et al., "Vortex: Extending the RISC-V ISA for GPGPU," MICRO, 2017.

[5] J. Bush et al., "Nyuzi: A GPGPU processor," open-source project.

[6] H. Genc et al., "Gemmini: Enabling systematic deep learning architecture evaluation," MICRO, 2021.

[7] W. Snyder, "Verilator," open-source project.

[8] Cocotb contributors, "cocotb: a coroutine-based testbench framework," open-source project.

[9] S. Noltmann, "NEORV32: an open-source RISC-V soft core," open-source project.

[10] SkyWater Technology and Google, "SkyWater 130 nm open PDK."

[11] Efabless, "OpenLane 2: an open-source ASIC flow," open-source project.

[12] The OpenROAD Project, "OpenROAD: toward a self-driving, open-source digital layout implementation tool chain."

[13] Z. Smith, "sv2v: SystemVerilog to Verilog conversion," open-source project.